



ON THE WRITE LINE

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ICC'S DEDICATED TEST MATCH FUND A BIG STEP FORWARD

Ever since the Indian broadcasters as well as **corporate sponsors** came to the fore, the various cricket boards have gotten more money than ever before from the ICC.

Shikhar Dhawan's retirement from all forms of the game is going to leave the sport poorer than before. The ever-smiling, ever-positive Shikhar, also fondly called 'Gabbar', was a player of enormous talent. But as befalls opening batters, a lean series or tournament can mean the selectors wielding the axe. In later years, injuries were part of Shikhar's career, which seldom allowed him to fully display his skill and probably helped him make the decision to quit the game while he was still enjoying being part of the circuit.

Taking that call is the hardest thing to do. But when the body tells the mind, 'Enough, enough', then that's the right time to go. **Retired cricketers today have many more avenues open to stay connected with the game, and Shikhar could well avail of them.** There's no doubt that whatever he chooses to do, he will do it with the same cheer that he brought to the game and was loved by teammates and fans for.

On the field, with Test matches being played around the same time in different parts of the world, the red-ball game is back in the news. Along with that also comes the news of a special Test match fund being planned by the ICC to help some countries that are struggling to sustain the longer format. Ever since the Indian

broadcasters as well as corporate sponsors came to the fore, the various cricket boards have gotten more money than ever before from the ICC.

Still looking at the neighbours' garden and then comparing it to yours is an old human quirk. With it come the complaints and excuses about why they are not getting the same as the others. It would be worthwhile to do a forensic audit of where the ICC's revenue share to the various boards goes. That would be far more revealing and could well nullify the case of giving additional share to the usual moaners. Make no mistake, whatever share the various boards are getting is more than enough to run the game in their countries and still have something left over. Depending on getting an increasing share of the ICC pie makes for lazy administration, for then, they just have to enjoy the perks of office without looking to strengthen the game in their country.

That said, it is a good idea for the ICC to suggest that the home team should bear the hotel and internal travel costs of the visiting country's team. **That can be a big relief for some, for sure, and would help them balance their budget to a great extent.** Clearly, there has to be a minimum standard set for hotels and travel; otherwise, like it happened in the past,